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‘Clown show’ shutdown puts workers in limbo

Thousands struggle with furloughs, no paychecks

Between **650,000-800,000** federal employees have been furloughed nationally, according to the Partnership for Public Service, and more than **1 million** are still working — mostly without pay.

More than half of Massachusetts’ estimated **46,000 federal employees** — about **25,000** — have faced furloughs or are working without pay because of the shutdown.

By Anjali Huynh, Katie Johnston, Laura Crimaldi, and Jason Laughlin
GLOBE STAFF

As congressional Democrats and Republicans remain locked in a standoff to reopen the government, federal workers in Massachusetts are facing chaos and confusion over whether they will get paid, or have jobs to return to if they are furloughed.

More than half of Massachusetts’ estimated 46,000 federal employees — about 25,000 — have faced furloughs or are working without pay because of the shutdown, according to the American Federation of Government Employees, or AFGE, a union of federal workers.

That number is part of a bleak national picture, in which federal workers say they’re acutely feeling the shutdown’s effects as many have now missed paychecks since the shutdown began Oct. 1. Hundreds of thousands of employees across the country are working without any certainty they will be paid when it ends. And President Trump and his Cabinet are seeking to permanently dismiss even more federal workers, adding to the mass layoffs the government carried out earlier this year.

“It’s a clown show,” said Max Stier, president of Partnership for Public Service, a Washington

SHUTDOWN, Page A10

‘NO KINGS’ PROTESTERS MARCH ACROSS THE NATION

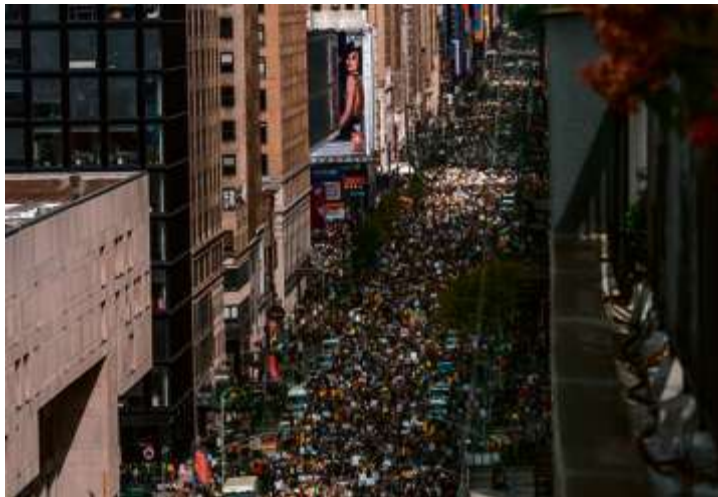
Demonstrators joined in cities large and small to protest the actions of President Trump. Clockwise from below, marchers on Boston Common cheered for Senators Elizabeth Warren and Ed Markey; in Manhattan, Seventh Avenue was filled; and in Memphis, costumed demonstrators waved to passersby. **A11, B1.**



CRAIG F. WALKER/GLOBE STAFF



JAN SONNENMAIR/GETTY IMAGES



ADAM GRAY/NEW YORK TIMES

A strong mayor faces some strong criticism



LANE TURNER/GLOBE STAFF

Thomas Koch is the longest-serving chief executive in Quincy history.

Quincy’s Koch slammed for pay raise, religious statues

By Brian MacQuarrie
GLOBE STAFF

QUINCY — Sitting in a sumptuous conference room at City Hall, seven-term Mayor Thomas Koch leans forward at the end of a long, polished table and says, without a trace of irony, “I’d do this job for free.”

It’s a declaration he’s made before, but it’s one that makes his opponents roll their eyes and groan in disbelief. Koch has won City Council approval for a \$126,000 raise, to \$285,000, that would make him the highest-paid mayor in Massachusetts and one of the highest-paid in the country.

And he’s not shy about defending the massive hike, which angered so many constituents that a local advocacy group tried, but so far has failed, to put a rollback of his raise before voters on the November ballot. The group is challenging the city’s rejection of its petition in court, alleging Quincy officials disqualified hundreds of valid signatures.

“The minute an elected official goes for a raise, all hell breaks loose,” Koch said in an

QUINCY, Page A13

Partisan battle lines drawn on America’s 250th

Despite hope for unity, Trump seeks to put MAGA stamp on festivities

By Jim Puzzanghera
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — The Instagram page for America250 was a haven of nonpartisan patriotism throughout the summer as it sought to build momentum for the nation’s milestone birthday bash on July 4, 2026.

The official account for the congressionally authorized commission organizing the commemoration highlighted notable anniversaries — Martin Luther King Jr.’s “I Have a Dream Speech,” the creation of the National Park Service, the dates that half-a-dozen states joined the Union. It also tried to engage followers with quizzes and polls, such as choosing “the most American food

ever” (winner: the hot dog).

Then on Sept. 11, a different kind of post appeared on the page.

“America is in mourning. God bless Charlie Kirk,” it read under a black-and-white photo of the conservative activist, who had been assassinated the day before. The reaction was immediate.

“Crazy political for America 250,” one commenter wrote. “What about the politicians in Minnesota and the countless souls lost in school shootings?” wrote another. While some people said they supported the post and it received more than 1,200 likes, the majority of the comments were negative. Numerous people vowed to unfollow

the account.

The hope has been that America’s 250th anniversary — its semiquincentennial — would be a unifying celebration for a divided nation, like the bicentennial was in 1976. But the United States is showing that it can’t even plan a birthday bash these days without it devolving into partisanship.

Critics blame President Trump, who they say has been increasingly politicizing the commemoration as he seeks to put a MAGA stamp on an event that long has fascinated him.

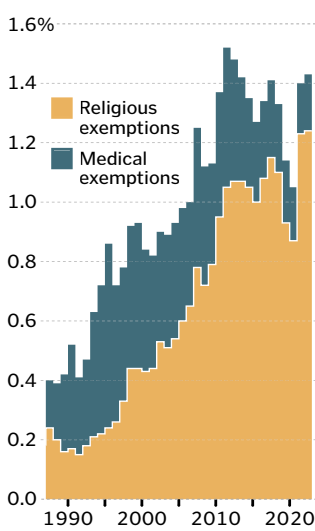
He turned the Army’s 250th birthday celebration in June into an elaborate Wash-

250, Page A12

Pediatricians grapple with dropping unvaccinated kids

Immunization exemptions

Religious and medical exemptions granted for kindergarten immunization in Massachusetts



SOURCE: Massachusetts Department of Public Health Immunization Division, Kindergarten Immunization Surveys, 1984-2024
GLOBE STAFF

Face medical dilemma to protect children in offices

By Kay Lazar
GLOBE STAFF

A group of pediatricians in Burlington turned to an example from history to explain why it requires patients to be vaccinated. Benjamin Franklin, they wrote in their vaccination policy, endured “guilt and remorse” after he rejected inoculating his sickly son.

A pediatric practice in Quincy took a more straightforward approach: “By not vaccinating, you are putting your child at unnecessary risk for life-threatening illness and disability, and even death,” its vaccine policy read. “If you should absolutely refuse to vaccinate your child despite all our efforts,” according to its policy, “we may ask you to find another healthcare provider who shares your views.”

Pediatricians across Massachusetts said they’re encountering a growing number of parents with questions, misinformation, or hesitancy about vaccines.

The consternation and confusion mean pediatric practices are increasingly facing an ethical dilemma: Should they drop unvaccinated families — and not accept new ones who decline to vaccinate

VACCINE, Page A10



Renters’ rights

No rats or leaks; what you don’t need to tolerate. Address, H1.

An evening in the orchestra pit is living proof that not everything can be automated, writes Meredith Goldstein. **SundayArts, N1.**

Officials at Logan Airport aim to cut travelers’ stress with the addition of therapy dogs. **SundayTravel, N15.**

The Wang Theater has been on the brink of failure over and over again. But 100 years after it opened, it’s still packing the house. **Globe Magazine.**

After 50 years, the 1975 World Series remains a magical memory — for fans and baseball writers alike, writes Dan Shaughnessy. **Sports, C1.**

Fall’s promise

Sunday: Sunny, pleasant. High: 65-70. Low: 54-59.

Monday: Rain, wind. High: 63-68. Low: 48-53.

Complete report, **C24.** Deaths, **C18-22.**

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